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The “Hundred-Lash” Rule

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The “Hundred-Lash” Rule

A rebuke impresses a man of discernment more than a hundred lashes a fool. An evil man is bent only on rebellion; a merciless official will be sent against him. (Proverbs 17:10-11)

Flog a mocker, and the simple will learn prudence; rebuke a discerning man, and he will gain knowledge. (Proverbs 19:25)

We’ve all seen a teen like this. He may have been the kid who was always in trouble in high school, the bully who even the principal or the police couldn’t break, or the gang member who ended up as every one predicted he would, serving hard time. After he was scolded, he sneered. After he was disciplined, he defied the authorities and dared them to do more. Incurable.

No doubt King Solomon had seen his share of rebellious people. In observing what fools they were (his word), he noted that there was a measuring stick for their folly. In the passages above, he describes a sliding scale in dealing with disobedience —“rebuke” on one end and “one hundred lashes” on the other. It is a general principle that authorities will use only as much discipline as is sufficient to bring compliance. If a rebuke works, they typically won’t waste the time and energy on more extreme discipline.

Thus, the formula: the greater the resistance, the more severe the discipline. In effect, we can determine our punishment.

Principle: The severity of the discipline is in direct correlation to the severity of the rebellion; if a rebuke brings submission, the rod will not follow.

Then the wise king observed that some people became submissive and compliant with no discipline at all! What factor in them accomplished this? “Discernment,” a factor in wisdom. A wise student of authority will learn quickly how one ends up in the principal’s office or in jail—by observation and not by acting out.

Principle: Figure out quickly what is necessary to avoid the wrath of an authority figure, and promptly comply with directions. Not doing so will bring painful “Lashes.”

Joyful submission to authority is not complicated. Rebellion is. When our kids asked with a whine, “Why do I have to take out the trash?” We understood that this was not a search for knowledge about the necessity for trash pickup. So we responded, “Take out the trash first. Then we will talk about why it is a necessary task.” Obedience isn’t complicated. Even the “simple” can figure it out.

Principle: Rebellion always complicates things, and rebels create chaos; immediate, joyful compliance simplifies life, for everybody.

Trust and obey. There is no other way...

[from “*Wisdom for the Trenches*” by Dr. Larry W. Poland]